The Snake's Tongue

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AI that took part in writing this text: Claude (Anthropic), ChatGPT (OpenAI), Gemini (Google)
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Look at the tip of a fountain pen. The nib is split in two. Ink runs down the narrow slit between the two tines and lands on the paper as a single line. This nib resembles a snake's tongue: both have two working blades.

The pen wrote everything that lives depended on: laws, treaties, sentences, prescriptions, wills. It was far from a harmless object. The pen, they say, is mightier than the sword. But a pen writes nothing by itself. It is guided by the hand of a human author.

Today we have a new split pen. One of its tines is a human, the other a machine. There are two tines because there are two kinds of speech: one grew out of life, the other out of computation. The text comes out of the cleft — the gap between them. This pen already writes scientific papers, reference books for doctors, police reports, draft court rulings. Many people are ashamed of this pen: they hide its trace — the use of AI — and are embarrassed by its help, by its presence in the text. But, you know, it is too late to turn away from this phenomenon in our lives: we already write with it. The real question is whether we understand what we are writing with. Who answers for what is written is clear: the human author.

Two tines

For a person, a word is what will happen next to him and to those close to him. Does she love me or not — will I have children. Did my boss understand me — will I be paid for the work. Paid — the children are fed. Not paid — the children are out in the frost. Cold does not accept explanations.

A surgeon has cut through an artery and says to the nurse: “Clamp!” If she does not understand, the patient bleeds to death. A sentry shouts at a man who has wandered up to his post: “Halt or I'll shoot!” If he does not understand, he dies. A child learns the word “hot” by getting burned. We learn words where a mistake costs something. For a living being, the meaning of a word is the price of a mistake. A mistake hurts.

A language model computes. It picks the next word from the links between words in human texts. A word from the human dictionary is glued onto the result of the computation. “I think”, “I'm afraid I may be wrong”, “this matters” — these are labels. The industry made them more human: the people who train AI models were shown two machine answers, asked to choose the better one, and in this way the model was taught to give answers that sound human [1]. In other words, the model was trained to imitate human speech. To imitate.

Behind the label, AI has no children to feed and no body that can bleed. Whatever the model writes, nothing happens to the model itself: its parameters are the same before the answer and after. “It doesn't care” — I would say that about a person; about a machine, only in quotation marks.

From the outside, it is one language — English. Inside, it is two languages, of entirely different origins. As with our pen: two tines, but one line on the paper, and the line does not show which tine drew it.

Harnad asked how a symbol gets its meaning inside a system, and not only for someone looking from outside [2]. Birhane and McGann tie human speech to the body and to vulnerability [3]. Bottazzi Grifoni and Ferrario write about the illusion of communicating with models [4]. Elan Barenholtz argues that a model's language does not describe reality but continues itself [5]. About the machine, I think he is right. But he goes on to suggest that the same may be true of humans. No: a person learns words where a mistake can cost a life.

People, too, often fail to understand each other. But misunderstanding between people creaks: a person's “I understand” costs him something — his work, his reputation, his relationships. A machine's “now I see” costs nothing and does not change the next text. The person nods, the machine carries on smoothly, and the gap in understanding stays silent and invisible to the author. The machine and the human speak different kinds of speech, different languages. They put very different meanings into the same words. This is the bilingualism of hybrid text, even though formally it is written in one shared human language — English, Russian or any other.

A tongue that searches

A snake does not flick its tongue to speak; it flicks it to hunt. It searches. The tongue gathers scent particles from the air and carries them back into the head, to a special organ. The fork lets it sample two points at once and find the direction to its prey [6]. The tongue does not leave the mouth at random but with a purpose. And it is directed by the head — the snake's own neural network.

Composing hybrid text works the same way in a search. I feel a difficulty but do not yet know the right words: I have hit a wall. I want to find those who have already picked the fruit I need: who walked this path before me, or walk beside me now. Marcia Bates described searching as “berrypicking”: what you find changes the question itself [7]. AI with search connects my personal difficulty to a field I did not know. A reference lets me check that connection.

In such a search the goal is only roughly visible. Flower and Hayes described how a writer's goals change with what he learns while writing [8]. So a thought born in a conversation with AI is already a result. A machine's answer can be accepted, disputed, or used to develop the topic. The machines helped me most where they were wrong and I noticed it: my “thought without weight” was born from someone else's “weight”. Advait Sarkar proposes building AI that challenges rather than obeys [9].

Why the snake's tongue leaves the mouth

Ancient man picked up a stick, the first tool, to reach a fruit. From a stick he made a bow, brought meat home from the hunt, fed his family and his kin — and survived. For me, a text is that same stick, an extension of the hand. And AI today is an “extension of the intellect”. By fruit I mean a result that matters in life: a solved problem, a skill, an income, help for the people close to you,

understanding of yourself or of another. In a search, the fruit can also be a question you could not grasp before, or a clearer view of the events and situations of our lives.

Hence two kinds of text. Tool texts bring the author and the reader closer to that very fruit. Noise texts say: “Look at me, here I am, this is what I'm like.” A noise text will not feed a family. This idea has predecessors. In 1930 Vygotsky called language and writing psychological tools, while noting that a sign does not work the way a stick does [10]. In 1962 Engelbart wrote about augmenting human intellect: a person together with his means copes better with a hard situation [11].

A tool has two results: the product and the skill. In a study by Bastani and colleagues, school students with an ordinary GPT-4 helper solved practice problems better. But in the exam without AI, that group scored on average 17% lower than the control group [12]. If I need a letter, a finished letter is fruit enough. If I need to learn, the fruit is what I can then do myself, having gained new skills.

The head

A snake's tongue is forked — that is its anatomy. But our new pen is stronger than a snake's tongue. It is more like a flying dragon with a forked tongue, and a person rides on its back. In “Avatar”, the rider joins his braid to the creature's nerve tendrils — the film calls this bond tsaheylu. In flight they act as one. The strength belongs to the creature; where to fly is decided by the rider. The creature has to be tamed first, and the one on its back answers for the flight. So it is with hybrid text: the machine gives strength and speed; the person gives the idea, the meaning, the direction and his human signature.

Now the main point. The current view is that, in writing a text, AI is the same as paper, type, the typewriter, the printing press. Who typed the words is a technical question. The author is the one who signed. He is the one who answers. This is already written into the rules of medical journals: AI cannot be an author because it cannot be accountable for the work [13].

So we see: it is not only the language that writes texts that has split. The words we use to describe the world are splitting too. And for many phenomena connected with AI there are no descriptive words yet. “I think, therefore I am,” wrote Descartes. Today a machine “thinks” in a dialogue, yet it does not live or exist as a subject. Descartes himself believed in 1637 that a machine could never reply meaningfully to whatever is said to it [14]. Now it does. We cannot describe the new reality fast enough, so we put in props. Even the rule “the author is the one who signed” is a legal prop. It does not describe how the text was born; it is an agreement, like the “legal person” once was. By origin, in fact, there are two authors: a human and a machine. By responsibility, one — and that one is the human.

A signed hybrid document becomes a product in which the author is a human and the machine is the means of giving shape to his thoughts. The one who signs must know this. Paper adds no words of its own; the machine does. And it does so smoothly: from the finished text you cannot tell whose word is whose. In a long chain, an author voices a guess, a machine retells it more confidently, the next model takes the retelling as fact. The reference at the end is still real, but the claim is already

different. A person has to learn not only to synthesize such hybrid text but also to check, refine and edit it.

In May 2025 the US government published a report on children's health. It was found to cite at least seven studies that do not exist, and 37 of its footnotes carried the marker “oaicite”, a trace of ChatGPT generating citations [15]. The marker was noticed not by the report's authors but by journalists.

So before signing, I ask a text three questions. What am I claiming here — and have my distinctions and my degree of certainty survived? What is it based on: what does the source confirm, what is my conclusion, what is a guess? What will others do, relying on this text? Who typed the words does not matter. What matters is where a new claim came from, and whether it is needed at all — here, in this text.

We already write with this pen — a pen that gives birth to hybrid texts

This is not the future. This is our “now”. At least 13.5% of 2024 biomedical abstracts were processed with language models [16]. UpToDate answers doctors through generative AI; in November 2025 its drug reference was added too [17]. In September 2026 Russia's Supreme Court approved a concept under which AI will draft court rulings and assist in sentencing. The decision and the signature stay with the judge [18]. Under a 2025 California law, a police report written with AI must say so, and the first draft must be kept [19]. The US Department of Energy tested an AI that wrote a 208-page chapter of a nuclear reactor licence application in about a day — instead of four to six weeks [20]. A global database already lists more than two thousand court cases with AI fabrications, including rulings by judges [21].

People respond in different ways. Some hide it. More than half of employees worldwide conceal that they use AI [22]. The em dash became an “AI tell”, and OpenAI made ChatGPT stop using it when users ask [23]. Others hunt the trace with detectors. Still others turn up their noses: Merriam-Webster chose “slop” — low-grade machine content — as its word of 2025 [24], and mentions of “neuroslop”, the Russian internet's word for it, grew almost twentyfold in Russian-language social media in 2026 [25]. But looking away will not work. The hybridization of text by humans and machines has become the direction of all the text on the planet. It has to be understood, and we have to learn to use it.

AI is a machine tool that turns out both tool texts and noise texts. Printing used to be expensive, and the threshold was high. Now it has collapsed. As early as 1971, Herbert Simon wrote that a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention [26]. Now the wealth is almost free, and useful texts drown in noise. Hence the temptation to draw a quarantine line: to separate “antediluvian” texts, written before the AI era, from today's hybrid ones (this text is an example too). As if young models could thus be protected from infection — from texts already processed by their “AI grandmothers”. But expensive printing never guaranteed truth. And there is no date after which texts became worse.

Still, such fears are well founded. If generations of models learn from what earlier models produced, rare cases get lost and distortions pile up. This is called model collapse [27]. A new model needs

fresh information, yet it arrives already passed through “AI grandmothers”. But when the original data were kept and synthetic data added to them, collapse did not occur in experiments [28]. And the Phi-1 model was trained partly on textbooks written by GPT-3.5 [29]. It is not about who typed the words. It is about selection.

Selecting for usefulness

Young models should most likely be “fed” tool texts, whether or not AI involvement is declared. Similar selection is already done. For the FineWeb-Edu corpus, pages were selected for “educational value” as judged by a model. This improved some benchmarks, while overly strict selection made others worse [30]. My measure is different: useful fruit in the life of a living person, confirmed by the result.

Usefulness is not a property of a text but a relation between the text, the reader and the task it serves. There is usefulness that is confirmed, usefulness that is expected, and usefulness not yet established. The last is not yet noise: an unfinished thought can be the blank for a future tool — that very “stick”. And what is useful to a person is not yet useful to a model. It has to be measured separately: the text itself, what changed in the person, and what changed in the model.

The most valuable unit for training is an episode of work on a task. It shows what the person needed, what the machine proposed, where they diverged, what the person objected, on what grounds they revised, and how it ended. A human “you've answered something else again” carries information about the goal that no smooth answer contains. That is the head correcting the tongue. Add a check: what was applied, what did not work, what confirmed it. Then a conversation with a machine becomes material on which the next model learns to hold a human goal. The main idea of this essay: hybrid texts can train the AI of the near future. In a few years, mostly hybrid texts will be circulating in the information space. That is the vector of technological development.

So far this is a hypothesis. It can be tested on a set of real tasks: train models on final texts and on episodes, and compare which holds the person's goal better. Who could train models this way and earn from it, and on what terms, I wrote about in “The Blind Kittens” [31]. That takes repeatable quality, an affordable cost of selection, and someone who needs such material.

The mark of the cutter

A non-fiction text of our time need not be smoothed out to look purely human. The author's signature is his decision to release the text as it is, to people and to machines. Some machine roughness can be left as a trace of the method. Like the mark of a milling cutter on metal. Like the imprint of wooden formwork on concrete, which architects leave on purpose.

But a cutter's mark and a gouge are different things. Texture can stay: machine intonation, turns of phrase. Defects must go: errors, invented facts and references. In the children's health report, the “oaicite” marker was a trace — and it was exactly the trace that exposed the defect. The law is already moving this way. California requires the first draft of a police report to be kept. Russia's Supreme Court concept requires the system to label its own decisions [32].

The snake does not lie: that is simply how it is made. A pen does not write by itself. The danger is not in the forked tongue or the split nib, but in an author's head that has forgotten the fork. A surgeon says “Clamp!” For the nurse, that is the patient's life; for the machine, it is a word that can be moved into another sentence. As long as the human author remembers this, the hybrid pen is useful, and working with it yields real knowledge. It is the person who reaches the result, the fruit. And it is the person who answers for what is written.

In this text I have deliberately left traces of machine processing — like the mark of a milling cutter on metal or the imprint of formwork on concrete: they show the method by which the material was made. This is not carelessness. This is what a text of our time looks like — hybrid, under a human signature. I removed defects: errors and invented facts. I kept the texture.

It's time to stop being ashamed of AI. What do you think, reader? Maybe I'm wrong?

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